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Greece: National Bank Holiday, 2015¹

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Abstract

In December 2014, deposit outflows from Greek banks intensified owing to political uncertainty following the announcement of a snap presidential election and a subsequent crash of the Greek stock market. This led to a liquidity crisis in the first half of 2015. Intensifying political uncertainty, worsening liquidity, and volatility in the macroeconomic and financial markets environment peaked in the first half of 2015. The crisis was exacerbated by a February decision by the European Central Bank (ECB) that made it difficult for Greek banks to continue borrowing from its monetary policy-related liquidity programs. On June 28, 2015, the ECB announced a decision not to allow the Bank of Greece to expand current levels of emergency liquidity assistance to Greek banks because of the failure of the troika—the ECB, the International Monetary Fund, and European Union (EU)—to prolong their Economic Adjustment Program for Greece. In response, Greek authorities passed an act on that same day, initiating a bank holiday to safeguard the Greek banking sector. The holiday was initially set to last until July 6, 2015, but was later extended multiple times, until banks reopened on July 20, 2015. At that time, banks reopened following an agreement with the EU on the Third Economic Adjustment Program for Greece. The banks reopened with capital controls still in place, which lasted until September 2019. The holiday applied to all banks operating in Greece. From the end of the holiday through the end of 2015, Greek deposits stabilized, and in December 2015, deposit inflows were recorded for the Greek banking system.

Keywords: bank holiday, Greece, European Sovereign Debt Crisis

¹ This case study is part of the Yale Program on Financial Stability (YPFS) selection of New Bagehot Project modules considering bank holiday and fund suspension programs. A survey of all the cases in this series (Wiggins et. al. 2025) and the cases underlying it are available from the *Journal of Financial Crises* at <https://elischolar.library.yale.edu/journal-of-financial-crises/>.

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Overview

This case study is about a bank holiday imposed on the Greek banking sector and related assistance the Greek government provided to the financial sector in summer 2015. The Greek banking sector subsequently stabilized by the end of 2015.

In 2013, Greece completed the process of recapitalizing its four largest banks with a combination of private and public funding. Smaller banks were resolved through mergers with one of the four largest banks (Hardouvelis and Vayanos 2023). For more information on individual banks that were resolved and recapitalized, see Schaefer-Brown (2024a); Schaefer-Brown (2024b); Schaefer-Brown (2024c); Schaefer-Brown (2024d).

In December 2014, Greek banks began experiencing significant deposit outflows owing to political uncertainty following the announcement of a snap presidential election and a subsequent crash of the Greek stock market. Following this, during the first half of 2015, Greece experienced a liquidity crisis in which Greek banks lost EUR 47.6 billion in deposits through withdrawals, or 27.5% of the deposit base (EC 2015a; Ellyatt 2014).

A number of factors contributed to the liquidity crisis, including an increase in nonperforming loans, uncertainty about the country’s debt sustainability, and a debate about whether Greece would exit the euro area following the results of the January 2015 elections. In addition, in February, the European Central Bank (ECB) decided that it would no longer accept Greek government bonds as collateral under its lending programs because of concerns about the sustainability of Greek debt. This meant Greek banks could no longer use Eurosystem open market operations (and the lending facility) to raise liquidity at 0.05% and instead had to

Key Terms

Purpose: Preventing bank runs and buying time for the government to negotiate a bailout package with the EU, ECB, and IMF after negotiations had failed and the ECB declined to expand the provision of ELA

Announcement Date June 28, 2015

End Date July 18, 2015

Legal Authority The president of the Hellenic Republic passed a legislative act on June 28, 2015, which was also ratified by the Greek parliament, initiating the holiday and establishing restrictions

Administrators The minister of finance had the power to change restrictions during the holiday as well as shorten or lengthen the holiday

Communication and Disclosure Greek authorities published the initial act in the Government Gazette; there was minimal communication following this publication

Permitted Withdrawals ATM withdrawals of EUR 60 per card were permitted each day

Treatment of Depositors or Investors ATM withdrawals were restricted, and capital controls remained in place at the end of the holiday

Outcomes From August 2015 through the end of the year, deposits stabilized; in December 2015, Greece recorded deposit inflows

Notable Features Online banking and the use of credit and debit cards remained available for payments within Greece

resort to the emergency liquidity assistance (ELA) mechanism—funding provided by the Bank of Greece (BoG) but under the control of the ECB—which had a rate of 1.55% at the time (Andruszkiewicz et al. 2020; BoG 2016).

On June 27, 2015, the Eurogroup denied the extension of its current financial system agreement with Greece, the Second Economic Adjustment Program. The Second Economic Adjustment Program began in March 2012 and was aimed at decreasing Greece's public debt ratio. On June 28, 2015, the ECB denied the extension of additional ELA from the BoG to Greek banks, citing the failure to prolong the Economic Adjustment Program for Greece as a reason for the denial (Council of the European Union 2012; ECB 2015a; ESM n.d.; European Council 2019a; Greece 2015).

The same day, the president of the Hellenic Republic (as Greece is formally known) passed an act initiating a bank holiday along with capital controls. During the holiday banks were closed, but cash withdrawals of EUR 60 per day per card from ATMs were allowed as well as transactions with credit cards and electronic banking within Greece. The banks were to initially reopen on July 6, but the holiday was extended through July 18. The banks reopened on July 20, 2015, with capital controls still in place until September 2019. Capital controls included restrictions on capital transfers and payments abroad, which primarily affected dealings with foreign suppliers and creditors. During the bank holiday, depositors withdrew an additional EUR 2.8 billion, while staying under the EUR 60 per day limit. Also during the holiday, Greece defaulted on its loan from the International Monetary Fund (IMF), missing a payment on June 30 and requesting an extension (Andruszkiewicz et al. 2020; EC 2015a; Greece 2015; IMF 2015; Piraeus 2015a).

Early in July, Greece carried out a snap referendum on proposed terms for an international bailout. On July 5, Greece voted against the bailout, so the country had to return to the negotiating table. On July 8, 2015, the European Stability Mechanism (ESM) board of governors and the European Commission (EC) began to assess risks to the financial stability of the euro area and the debt sustainability of Greece before agreeing to begin negotiations on a new Economic Adjustment Program on July 10, 2015. On July 12, in a summit, the member countries of the euro area reached an agreement regarding the Greek crisis. The Eurogroup ratified this agreement on August 14, 2015, and the EC signed the agreement for the Third Economic Adjustment Program with Greece on August 19, 2015 (BBC News 2015; European Council 2019b; Piraeus 2015b).

From August 2015 through the end of the year, Greek deposits stabilized. Deposits at Piraeus Bank, one of the country's four systemically important (significant) banks (directly supervised by the ECB, since November 4, 2014, within the Single Supervisory Mechanism [SSM]), rose by EUR 1.8 billion in the fourth quarter of 2015 (Piraeus 2016). In December 2015, deposit inflows were recorded for the Greek banking system. Greek authorities eventually lifted capital controls in September 2019 (Andruszkiewicz et al. 2020; Piraeus 2016).

Figure 1: Timeline of the 2015 Greek Banking Holiday

Date	Event
March 2012	The Second Economic Adjustment Program begins
Feb. 4, 2015	The ECB decides it will not accept Greek government bonds and bonds guaranteed by the Greek government as collateral under ECB lending programs
June 27, 2015	The Eurogroup denies the extension of the Second Economic Adjustment Program
June 28, 2015	The ECB denies the expansion of Greek ELA and the Greek president responds by initiating the bank holiday and capital controls
June 30, 2015	Greece defaults on its loan payment to the IMF and requests an extension
July 5, 2015	Greece votes against terms for an international bailout
July 8, 2015	The ESM board of governors and the EC begin to assess risks to the financial stability of the euro area and the debt sustainability of Greece before negotiations on a new economic stability program could begin
July 10, 2015	Following the assessment, the ESM board of governors agrees that negotiations of a new Economic Adjustment Program can begin
July 12, 2015	Greece comes to an agreement with the euro area for the Third Economic Adjustment Program
July 18, 2015	Bank holiday ends
July 20, 2015	The banks reopen
Aug. 14, 2015	The Eurogroup ratifies the new Third Economic Adjustment Program with Greece
Aug. 19, 2015	The EC signs the Third Economic Adjustment Program for Greece
Sept. 1, 2019	Capital controls are fully lifted

Source: Author's analysis.

Summary Evaluation

The bank holiday prevented bank runs from worsening and gave the government time to negotiate with the European Union (EU), ECB, and IMF over the terms of the third bailout package, at a time when markets feared Greece's imminent exit from the EU (O'Brien 2015).

According to the BoG's annual report for 2015, the holiday and capital controls succeeded in containing deposit outflows and capital flight but also created distortions in the capital market, as well as in the market for goods and services. The report raised concerns that this could have indirect repercussions not yet gauged. One positive factor the report highlights is that the holiday and the subsequent capital controls encouraged the use of credit cards and electronic transfers, which were excluded from the holiday and supported private consumption and tax revenue (BoG 2016; Greece 2015).

An EC report from 2020 on the Greek crisis highlighted the 2015 bank holiday and capital controls as "critical in preventing a collapse of the Greek banking system" (Andruszkiewicz et al. 2020).

Context: Greece 2015–2016	
GDP (SAAR, nominal GDP in USD)	\$195.7 billion in 2015
	\$193.1 billion in 2016
GDP per capita (SAAR, nominal GDP in USD)	\$18,083.9 in 2015
	\$17,924.0 in 2016
Sovereign credit rating (long-term debt)	Moody's: Caa3 in 2015
	S&P: CCC+ in 2015
	Fitch: CCC in 2015
	Moody's: Caa3 in 2016
	S&P: B- in 2016
	Fitch: CCC in 2016
Size of banking system	\$246.6 billion in 2015
	\$230.4 billion in 2016
Size of banking system as a % of GDP	126% in 2015
	119.3% in 2016
Size of banking system as a % of financial system	Data not available in 2015
	Data not available in 2016
Five-bank concentration of banking system	100% in 2015
	100% in 2016
Foreign involvement in banking system	Data not available in 2015
	Data not available in 2016
Existence of deposit insurance	Yes in 2015
	Yes in 2016

Sources: Bloomberg; World Bank Deposit Insurance Dataset; World Bank Global Financial Development Database.

Key Design Decisions

- 1. Purpose: Greek authorities put in place the bank holiday to safeguard the Greek financial system after depositors withdrew more than one-quarter of all their deposits in the first half of 2015 and immediately after the euro area member states decided not to extend aid and the ECB declined the provision of further ELA.**

To safeguard the Greek banking sector from significantly worsening liquidity and a volatile macroeconomic and financial environment and following an ECB announcement that it would not expand ELA assistance to Greek banks, Greek authorities initiated a bank holiday on June 28, 2015. From the beginning of the political crisis in December 2014 to the beginning of the bank holiday on June 28, 2015, the banks lost EUR 47.6 billion in deposit outflows, which was 27.5% of the deposit base. The bank holiday applied to all banks that operated in Greece. The banks reopened on July 20, following an agreement with the EU on the Third Economic Adjustment Program for Greece (EC 2015a; Greece 2015; Piraeus 2015a; Piraeus 2015b).

- 2. Part of a Package: During the bank holiday, the central bank provided ELA, and the Greek authorities and euro area member states agreed on the Third Economic Adjustment Program for Greece, providing for recapitalization of the country's banks. The Hellenic Capital Market Commission closed the Athens Stock Exchange for the duration of the bank holiday.**

The ECB decision in February 2015 to stop accepting Greek government bonds as collateral made it significantly more difficult for Greek banks to access ECB lending. Following this decision, the Greek banking sector significantly increased its borrowings of ELA, provided by the BoG under the control of the ECB. ELA lending to Greek banks quickly rose to EUR 87 billion at the end of June 2015, amounting to 69% of total Eurosystem funding during this period. This trend started to reverse at the end of the bank holiday. By September 2015, ELA liquidity support had decreased by EUR 5.2 billion from June 2015, owing in part to the financing of EUR 86 billion included in the Third Economic Adjustment Program, agreed to during the holiday (Piraeus 2015b).

On July 12, 2015, the euro area member states reached an agreement on a Third Economic Adjustment Program for Greece. The Eurogroup ratified this agreement with Greece on August 14, 2015, and the EC signed it into immediate effect on August 19, 2015. The objective of the Third Economic Adjustment Program was to preserve financial stability and strengthen the banking system in Greece. The program included up to EUR 86 billion from the ESM. During the negotiation of the Third Economic Adjustment Program, the European Financial Stabilization Mechanism provided a bridge loan of EUR 7 billion to Greece which was to be repaid with funds provided under the Third Economic Adjustment Program (ECB 2015b; European Council 2019b; Piraeus 2015b).

As part of the Third Economic Adjustment Program the Greek government also agreed not to interfere with bank decision-making processes or the appointment of bank boards or

management and to permit banks to operate strictly on a commercial basis. The government monitored capital controls and restrictions on capital transfers and payments abroad, conditions that remained in place until 2019 (Andruszkiewicz et al. 2020; Piraeus 2015a).

At the same time as Greek authorities setting the restrictions on banking transactions, the Hellenic Capital Market Commission (HCMC) decided that the Athens Stock Exchange would remain closed throughout the bank holiday. Although the banks reopened on July 20, 2015, the HCMC extended its stock market closure to July 31, 2015. The Athens Stock Exchange reopened on August 3, 2015 (Piraeus 2015b).

3. Legal Authority: The bank holiday was initiated through an “act of legislative content” from the president of the Hellenic Republic.

On June 28, 2015, the president of the Hellenic Republic, upon the proposal of the cabinet of ministers, issued an “act of legislative content” initiating the bank holiday. The parliament then ratified the act, which entered into force once published in the Government Gazette. The inciting situation recited in this act was: “The extraordinarily urgent and unforeseeable need to protect the Greek financial system and the Greek economy in general from the liquidity shortage due to the Eurogroup decision of 27 June 2015 to deny the extension of the financial assistance (loan) agreement with Greece” (Greece 2015, 1).

Acts of legislative content were authorized by virtue of Article 44 of the Greek Constitution, which gave the president the power to issue such acts “under extraordinary circumstances of an urgent and unforeseeable need” and upon the proposal of the cabinet. These acts then had to be submitted to parliament within 40 days and be ratified by parliament within three months of their submission, or the act would no longer be in force. It is unclear when exactly this happened (Greece 2008).

The Greek authorities did not consult the ECB before initiating the bank holiday. The cabinet act from June 28 specified July 6 as the end of the holiday but allowed for the minister of finance to shorten or extend the holiday. The holiday was extended until the banks ultimately reopened on July 20 (EC 2015a; ECB 2016; Piraeus 2015b).

4. Administration: The minister of finance had the power to change the holiday restrictions and the time frame of the holiday; the BoG was responsible for imposing a fine on holiday breaches.

The initial cabinet act from June 28, which the cabinet of ministers proposed, the president passed, and the parliament ratified, established the restrictions of the bank holiday and its initial end date of July 6. The minister of finance could change restrictions and add additional restrictions as well as shorten or lengthen the holiday dates. The minister of finance was also responsible for addressing any issues that came up regarding the application of the holiday. The BoG imposed a fine of 10% of the amount of any transactions that were in breach of the holiday and any employee of a bank responsible for the breach was to be terminated. The act established a Committee for the Approval of Bank Transactions that could deem bank transactions necessary, exempting them from restrictions during the holiday. The committee consisted of five members drawn from the General Accounting Office, the Ministry of

Finance, the BoG, the Hellenic Bank Association, and the HCMC. It could determine transactions were “necessary for the safeguarding of a public or social interest, including, inter alia, transactions for medical expenses or imports of pharmaceutical products” (Greece 2015).

5. Governance: The bank holiday was imposed by Greek authorities, including the president, cabinet of ministers, and parliament.

The authorities involved in initiating the holiday were the president of the Hellenic Republic, the cabinet of ministers, and the Greek parliament. The Greek financial stability council decided on the capital controls put in place (Hope et al. 2015).

6. Communication and Disclosure: Communication throughout the holiday was limited. Authorities published the initial act in the Government Gazette and the BoG made a number of announcements regarding its limitations during the holiday.

Greek authorities announced the beginning of the holiday on June 28, 2015, on TV. The BoG put out an official announcement on June 29, 2015, stating that for the duration of the holiday it would only be carrying out transactions concerning the accounts of the Greek state, legal persons in public law, and social security funds (BoG 2015a; BoG 2015b; Hope et al. 2015).

Other than these announcements there was minimal communication from the Greek authorities or the EU regarding the bank holiday. Communication appears to resume once the euro area and the Greek authorities agreed on the Third Economic Adjustment Program.

7. Details of Holidays, Suspensions, or Gates: The holiday applied to all banks operating in Greece and allowed restricted withdrawals and some transactions and payments within Greece. The payment of pensions was exempted from the holiday’s restrictions.

The government of Greece imposed the holiday, which applied to all banks operating in Greece—including branches of foreign banks. During the holiday, banks were to remain closed to the public, with bank access allowed only for personnel deemed necessary for the implementation of the holiday and the preparation of resuming transactions with the public at the end of the holiday. During the holiday, the only transactions that could be carried out were:

- Cash withdrawals from ATMs, limited to EUR 60 per day per card (this could be amended by the minister of finance);
- Transactions with credit and debit cards within Greece for payments to accounts held in Greece;
- Payments with prepaid cards (not exceeding the balance of the card at the beginning of the holiday);

- Electronic web banking or telephone transactions for payments in Greece (payments to accounts held in Greece);
- Cash withdrawals from ATMs via cards that had been issued abroad (Greece 2015).

The payment of pensions was specifically exempted from the holiday's restrictions, and banks and their local branches could operate for this purpose (Greece 2015).

The minister of finance could modify, amend, and add restrictions. Restrictions did not apply to transactions with the BoG, cross-border payments paid to accounts held in Greece, settlement of transactions initiated before the beginning of the holiday, and other transactions deemed necessary by the Committee for the Approval of Bank Transactions, which the act specifically set up for that purpose. Overdue interest was not payable during the holiday and the maturity and payment of instruments was suspended during the holiday. BoG imposed a fine of 10% of the amount of any transactions that were in breach of the holiday and any employee of a bank responsible for the breach was to be terminated (Greece 2015).

8. Treatment of Depositors or Investors: Withdrawals were limited during the holiday and capital controls remained in place at the end of the holiday, but Greek authorities gradually removed them.

During the holiday, cash withdrawals from ATMs were limited to EUR 60 per day per card, and capital transfers and payments abroad were restricted. In addition to ATMs remaining open, online banking continued and credit and debit cards could be used for payments within Greece. Prepaid cards could be used up to the balance held on them at the date of the holiday. At the end of the bank holiday, capital controls—specifically restrictions on capital transfers and payments abroad—remained in place, but Greek authorities gradually removed them (Greece 2015; Piraeus 2015a).

The payment of pensions was specifically exempted from the holiday's restrictions and credit institutions and their local branches could operate for this purpose (Greece 2015).

9. Verification of Solvency: No verification of solvency was carried out during the holiday, but as part of the Third Economic Adjustment Program, which was agreed to during the holiday, in October 2015, the ECB carried out an assessment of four systemic Greek banks.

As part of the Third Economic Adjustment Program in Greece, in October 2015, the ECB's SSM carried out a comprehensive assessment of the four significant Greek banks using data from June 2015 under its direct supervisory remit. It included an asset quality review and stress test, examining a baseline and an adverse scenario. Following the assessment, the ECB required the banks to submit plans to cover their capital shortfalls (EC 2015a; EC 2015b; ECB 2015b).

On the other hand, the BoG conducted stress tests on those banks that were under its direct supervision within the SSM and imposed stricter management and reporting requirements on banks with regard to nonperforming loans (BoG 2016).

10. Other Conditions: Research has not revealed any additional conditions attached to the bank holiday.

There do not appear to have been any additional conditions that banks had to comply with during the holiday. As part of the Third Economic Adjustment Program, the government agreed to not interfere with banks' decision-making processes or board appointments (Andruszkiewicz et al. 2020; Piraeus 2015a).

11. Exit Strategy: Greek authorities maintained capital controls at the end of the bank holiday. During the holiday, Greek authorities also reached an aid agreement with the EU.

The bank holiday lasted three weeks and the capital controls introduced with the holiday were gradually removed after the end of the holiday. Authorities initiated the holiday with the cabinet act of June 28, 2015, which was subsequently revised at the end of the holiday to make restrictions milder but leaving in place restrictions on cash withdrawals and transferring funds. Authorities were able to reopen the banks after the agreement for the Third Economic Adjustment was reached between the Greek authorities and the EU (Piraeus 2015a; Piraeus 2015b).

In May 2017, authorities published a conditions-based road map for lifting the remaining capital controls, which were then gradually lifted until they were completely lifted in September 2019 (Andruszkiewicz et al. 2020).

The holiday and capital controls were expected to have "limited and short-term negative effects" on the economy for several reasons: There was an increase in the number of bank notes in circulation in the Greek economy between November 2014 and June 2015; there were no restrictions on the amount of electronic transactions within the country; many companies were prepared for the possibility of capital controls, so the controls did not affect their operations; and there was a limited impact on tourism which had originally been a concern (Piraeus 2015a).

At the end of the bank holiday, Greece had reached an agreement on a Third Economic Adjustment Program with the EC. This agreement and the liquidity assistance measures provided by the Eurosystem helped offset the trend of deposit outflows that had begun in late December 2014 and lasted until the beginning of the bank holiday (Piraeus 2015b).

12. Regulatory Changes: Research has not revealed any regulatory changes connected to the bank holiday.

Research has not revealed regulatory changes following the bank holiday.

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